beliefs were complicated, and the Cathars themselves had already split into more than one sect.* But all Cathars were dualists, dividing all things in the universe into good and evil, light and dark. As their contemporary Pierre des Vaux de Cernay writes, they held that there were two creators: ". . . one of invisible things, whom they called the benevolent god, and another of visible things, whom they named the malevolent god. The New Testament they attributed to the benevolent god but the Old Testament to the malevolent god, and rejected it altogether."[6] To be pure, the Cathars resisted as much interaction with the material world as possible: they fasted, rejected sex, and suffered through marathons of prayer and meditation.

They also rejected the orthodox doctrine of the Incarnation, since this required the benevolent God to tie himself to the enslaving, corrupt material world. This made Catharism a dangerous heresy; but even more dangerous, as de Cernay notes, was their attitude towards the authority of the church. "They said," he writes, "that almost all the Church of Rome was a den of thieves, and that it was the harlot of which we read in the Apocalypse."[7]

These beliefs, quietly spreading through the south since the 1140s, had found a particularly receptive home in the southern province of Languedoc, bordering the Pyrenees and the Mediterranean Sea. Languedoc was a relatively lawless chunk of Western Francia, where the authority of the local counts was weak and the local priests were poor, uneducated, and superstitious. To the people of Languedoc, Catharism offered a new kind of power: an authority centered only within themselves, a chance to rise through the ranks of the Cathars to the shining elite ranks of the perfected.

Innocent III had not been unaware of the gathering Cathar strength. In 1203 he had sent papal representatives to Languedoc to evaluate the strength of the movement, and in 1206 he had granted the request of a local priest to be allowed to preach in Languedoc, in an effort to evangelize the Cathars back into the orthodox fold. The priest, Dominic de Guzman, hailed from just over the mountains in Castile. He believed that the Cathars could be turned back to orthodoxy, if they saw that an orthodox clergyman could also lead an ascetic and pure lifestyle; he had met the papal representatives on their journey through Languedoc and been unimpressed by their approach. They were, he thought, displaying altogether too much pride and pomp. "It is not by the display of power and pomp, calvacades of retainers, and . . . gorgeous apparel, that these heretics win proselytes," he complained. "It is by zealous preaching, by apostolic humilty, by austerity. . . . Zeal must be met by zeal; false sanctitity by real sanctity; preaching falsehood by preaching truth." He himself traveled through Languedoc barefoot, arguing with the Cathars one on one.[8]